

PART A : DIAGNOSIS

Situation A : The Alert Nobody Responds To

1. The stated problem

According to Anil and Karthik, the problem is that the alert system is functioning properly, but department heads are not taking action despite receiving daily alerts. According to the CEO, the problem is that he still lacks visibility even after receiving automated reports every morning.

2. Actual stuffs going on underneath

The real issue is not lack of visibility.

The real issue is lack of ownership and actionable accountability.

The alert system is reporting information, but it is not assigning responsibility.

The email tells management that "Warehouse is red" or "Purchase is red," but nobody feels personally accountable for fixing it.

The alerts are informational rather than behavioral.

The system assumes that visibility automatically creates action.

People act when :

ownership is clear

- consequences are visible
- escalation paths exist
- priorities are defined

None of those exist in the current system.

Additionally, the alerts only show symptoms.

They do not show:

- who owns the issue
- why it happened
- what action is underway
- whether it is improving or worsening
- whether it has already been escalated

As a result, the CEO sees the same red items repeatedly.

The system creates awareness but not movement.

3. Evidence from the case

The advisor specifically noted :

The tracker shows department names, not individual names.

The advisor stated:

“If I see Warehouse delayed, who feels pressure?” Nobody.

The alert email contains:

- department
- status
- pending items

But it does not contain:

- individual accountability
- trend history
- escalation history
- ownership

The CEO's statement is highly revealing :

"I want to know what's happening on the floor, not what happened yesterday."

This means the CEO is asking for predictive visibility, not reporting visibility.

The current system only reports lagging indicators.

This organization believes that visibility equals accountability. What seems to happen here is that if there is visibility of an issue, then action would be taken. Visibility without ownership only results in observation, not intervention. The CEO gets the information, but nobody gets the accountability.

Situation B : The Blank Field

1. The stated problem

Anil and Karthik believe employees are not disciplined enough to fill root-cause fields properly.

2. Actual stuffs going on underneath

The problem is psychological safety.

The people aren't afraid to document for lack of effort.

They are afraid to document because telling the truth can harm their careers.

A culture has been fostered in which looking into the root cause is synonymous with pointing fingers.

In response, individuals safeguard their own interests by remaining ambiguous.

Empty spaces are not an absence of information.

Empty spaces are fear.

By not documenting the root causes, the supervisors are being perfectly rational in this context.

Why did Anil and Karthik miss it?

Because they interpreted behavior operationally instead of psychologically.

They saw :

"Field not filled"

and concluded :

"Discipline issue."

They never asked :

"What happens when somebody tells the truth?"

The supervisors provided the real answer.

3. Evidence from the case

Supervisor 1 stated :

“If I write what actually went wrong, tomorrow they will ask me 50 questions.”

Supervisor 2 stated :

“Last time I wrote the real root cause, the maintenance head got called out in front of everyone.”

This is extremely important.

The organization is punishing transparency.

Therefore employees hide information.

The missing root causes are not a data quality problem.

They are a trust problem.

They have unwittingly taught their employees that transparency is dangerous for them personally. In such environments, people optimise for self-protection not organisational learning. The blank root-cause field is not a documentation issue. It is a behavioral adaptation to a system that connects truth-telling with punishment.

Situation C : The Meeting That Eats the Day

1. The stated problem

Anil and Karthik believe the meeting runs long because technical issues require discussion.

2. Actual stuffs going on underneath

This is primarily a planning failure disguised as a meeting problem.

The organization has no daily operating plan.

Without a daily plan:

- everything becomes urgent
- everything becomes unplanned
- meetings become triage sessions

The meeting is being used as a substitute for planning.

Instead of reviewing execution, the meeting is discovering work.

That is why it expands endlessly.

The organization also mixes three different types of conversations:

- Status updates
- Problem solving
- Technical investigation

These should be separate forums.

When they are mixed together, meetings become operational black holes.

3.Evidence from the case

The advisor asked :

“Show me your daily plan”

No daily plan existed.

The advisor identified:

- Routine work
- Planned work
- Unplanned work

Nobody was tracking unplanned work.

Nobody was identifying root causes of interruptions.

The meeting was scheduled for 30 minutes but regularly ran for 60-90 minutes.

This is strong evidence that the meeting is compensating for planning failures elsewhere.

The meeting is merely the visible symptom. The real issue is that the organization lacks a planning architecture.

There were no schedule or agenda for the meeting as there were :

- No daily plans
- No categorization of work
- No separation of escalation vs discussion
- No tracking of unplanned work

PART B : INTERVENTION DESIGN

Situation A : Alert Nobody Responds To

1. First Conversation

My first conversation would be with two HODs whose departments have remained red for multiple days.

I would not start with the CEO.

I would ask :

"When you receive a red alert, what do you do next?"

"Walk me through your thought process."

"What prevents resolution?"

"What would make this alert genuinely useful for you?"

The objective is understanding behavior before redesigning the system.

2. Changes in the First Two Weeks

I would stop discussing departments.

I would start discussing owners.

Every red item must have:

- Owner Name
- Next Action
- Commitment Date

No new technology yet.

Just accountability.

Each morning:

"What changed since yesterday?"

not

"What is red?"

This changes the conversation from reporting to execution.

For the first week I would spend 30 minutes on the shop floor with one supervisor. I would ask him to show me how he follows deviations at this time. I wouldn't pull out my laptop. First, I'd identify where he's losing time and what's frustrating about existing reporting processes.

3. Tool Design

The dashboard would show :

Task:

Pending PO Approval

Owner :

Ramesh

Days Open:

5

Previous Escalations :

2

Trend:

Amber -> Red -> Red

Next Action:

Vendor confirmation pending

Expected Closure:

June 10

The CEO can immediately see:

owner

action

history

rather than only status.

Technology

- Excel
- Power Automate
- Power BI

Reason :

HODs already use Excel.

Adoption matters more than sophistication.

4. Getting Buy-In

I would sit beside the supervisor.

Not in a conference room.

I would say :

"I am not asking you to do more work. I am trying to reduce the number of times people ask you for updates."

Then I would demonstrate how one entry eliminates multiple follow-up calls.

I will show benefit first and ask compliance later.

Situation B : Blank Root Cause

1. First Conversation

I would privately meet supervisors.

Not management.

And ask a question:

"If you wrote the actual reason tomorrow, what would happen?"

The answer will reveal the trust gap.

2. Changes in the First Two Weeks

No changes to forms.

Instead :

Introduce "Learning Review."

Not "Failure Review."

Rules:

No naming individuals.

No public blame.

Focus only on:

- What happened
- Why it happened
- What system allowed it

The goal is rebuilding safety.

The organization has, in effect, turned its process improvement specialists into coordination specialists. The very ability hired to build scalable systems is being used up to sustain non-scalable behaviour as their time is spent on follow-up activity.

3. Tool Design

Root Cause Form

Fields:

What happened?

What allowed it?

What evidence supports this?

What preventive action is proposed?

An AI layer (Claude) suggests possible root-cause categories.

The supervisor can edit before submission.

Technology

- Excel Form
- Power Automate
- Claude API

Reason :

Reduce writing effort.

Improve consistency.

4. Getting Buy-In

I would use the previous incident.

Ask:

"Did the issue disappear because it wasn't documented?"

The answer is always no.

Then explain:

"The goal is preventing repeat incidents, not finding someone to blame."

Situation C: Meeting That Eats the Day

1. First Conversation

With COO.

Question:

"Which decisions truly require all 12 HODs in one room?"

Most discussions will not.

2. Changes in the First Two Weeks

Introduce three lanes:

Lane 1 :

Daily Status Review

Lane 2 :

Technical Problem Solving

Lane 3 :

Escalations

No mixing.

Meeting limit :

30 minutes.

Technical discussions moved elsewhere.

I would do a structured capability review with the SAP implementation partner before building parallel systems. The idea that "SAP can't do it" has been taken as truth without being checked independently, though.

3. Tool Design

Daily Board

Three sections:

- Today's Planned Work
- Today's Unplanned Work
- Blocked Items

Every item tagged.

This creates visibility into interruptions.

Technology

- Excel Tracker
- WhatsApp Notification
- Power Automate Reminder

Reason :

Minimal learning curve.

4. Getting Buy-In

I would calculate how much time the current meeting wastes monthly.

Then show supervisors:

"If we reduce this meeting by 30 minutes daily, each of you gets 11 hours back every month."

Time savings create adoption.

PART C : SCALE THINKING

1. What breaks first?

The most dangerous failure point is not technology.

It is dependency on people like **Anil** and **Karthik**.

Currently they are acting as human glue.

They follow up.

They chase.

They coordinate.

They fix problems personally.

When projects increase from 2 to 8, this becomes mathematically impossible.

The organization is functioning because Anil and Karthik compensate for missing systems.

At 8 projects, they will become queued.

2. What would I build in the first 3 months?

An Execution Ownership System.

Every task must contain:

- Owner
- Next Action
- Due Date
- Dependency
- Escalation Trigger

The system forces accountability before scale arrives.

3. What gets automated?

Automate:

- reminders
- escalation alerts
- trend reporting
- overdue detection
- dashboard updates

Machines are better at repetitive tracking.

What stays human?

Root-cause discussions Conflict resolution Priority decisions Cross-functional tradeoffs Coaching supervisors Trust building

These require judgment and emotional intelligence.

Automating them would destroy context.

It is not the tracker, the meetings, or the dashboards that break first. Instead, it's how dependent the organization becomes on a few key people who manually keep everything together. So, when those individuals hit a wall, everything falls apart.